

How Should We View Vietnam's Policy of Making English the Foundation of the Nation?

Zhihu

Vietnam's economy is undergoing leapfrog development; in ten to twenty years, Vietnam will face the real challenges of industrial upgrading and enterprises going overseas. By then, what language global researchers, multinational corporations, and commerce and trade use will become very important. Vietnam was never a colony of the British or American empires, and has no English-speaking population at home. Choosing English as its second language is a choice made by Vietnam's ruling group on the basis of its judgement of the future international situation. Vietnam's policy choice cannot be compared with India's or Singapore's; it is closer to Ethiopia's.

Some say Vietnam merely makes English a compulsory subject from grade one of primary school, and China has long done the same. That needs clarification: Vietnam has made English the second language of education — meaning that its subsequent mathematics, physics, and other science courses will be taught in English. Some secondary schools in Ho Chi Minh City have already begun piloting this. At least at the level of top-level design, Vietnam's emphasis on English is far higher than China's.

Vietnam's choice of English rather than Chinese has indeed upset many Chinese people. In many people's eyes, the Chinese learn English because of Anglo-American hegemony; now that China is about to seize hegemony, why can't Chinese be promoted worldwide? According to the analyses of many on Zhihu, China will replace American hegemony within ten years, even five. Can Vietnam's ruling group and the think tanks serving it fail to see a trend that Zhihu political commentators all see? Why has the Vietnamese government done something like joining the Nationalist Army in 1949?

I think the fundamental reason is that many people fail to recognise the differences between the historical conditions of British hegemony, American hegemony, and the hegemony China (soon to be, perhaps) obtains.

The foundation of British hegemony was that Britain was the first to complete its bourgeois revolution and industrialisation. Using its industrial hegemony, Britain grabbed the vastest colonies and left in them an English educational system and English-speaking middle and upper classes. From the formation of British hegemony to its systematic challenge, there were about a hundred years. When the other European and American countries completed their industrialisation, British hegemony ended.

The foundation of American hegemony was leading the bourgeois world-system against the Soviet socialist system, and in that process pushing the globalisation of capitalist production (before the 1980s, capitalist countries still had fairly complete industries — the US, for instance, still had large light industries in clothing and textiles. The mutual benefit of capital export cannot replace the competition of commodity export.) Within the American-led global division of labour, English gradually established itself as the lingua franca of trade, the common language of science and technology, and the internal language of multinational corporations. From the formation of American hegemony to its systematic challenge, there were about eighty years. After the Soviet Union's collapse, American hegemony lost its class-political foundation; what sustains it now is its residual technological strength, its military bases, and the inertia of the world capitalist order (the dollar, English).

Now it is China's turn. On what basis is China's hegemony formed? Under the American-led globalised order of the post-war era: accepting transferred industries, importing advanced means of production to complete infrastructure and industrial foundations, learning advanced technology through study abroad, working in foreign enterprises, and joint ventures, gradually building independent innovation capacity, and exploiting the dividend of cheap engineers and researchers to close the gap rapidly and overtake. China has begun to replace the United States.

But the historical conditions under which China obtains hegemony are completely different from America's. First, after the Second World War, the industrial capacity of the other capitalist countries had been destroyed by war; politically they faced revolution, and bourgeois rule hung by a thread. America even directly controlled the two great industrial countries, Japan and Germany. Second, in the post-war capitalist world-system, only China and India had the potential to reach America's level, but these two countries were too far behind; without the large-scale industrial transfer of Europe, America, and Japan, relying on their own strength alone they could probably not have reached America's industrial and scientific scale within a hundred years.

In the world of 2025, many things are different. First, China's industry is advanced, but other countries still have a good deal of industry; it has not suffered destructive blows. Second, there is no communist threat; there is no necessity that some country lead the capitalist world. Third, the former colonial countries are industrialising across the board; behind China — especially the big body of India — has already developed, and is enjoying the dividends of great-power competition. There are no vast agrarian regions left for you to colonise. In such a world, what kind of hegemony can China obtain? Even if it obtains hegemony, how many years can it maintain it?

I believe the Vietnamese ruling group's judgement should be: China's rise cannot change the basic rules of the global capitalist order. On the basis of this judgement, Vietnam naturally chose the so-called "English as the foundation of the nation."

As for the Chinese: in the next twenty years, many will feel China has become the most advanced country and Chinese will soon replace English as the global lingua franca. But this idea will very likely not come true. Precisely in the 2050s, as a new batch of former British colonies and countries like Vietnam and Ethiopia that have actively chosen English as their national foundation complete their industrialisation and begin to strike at high-tech industries, English will in turn deliver the Chinese a bit of a shock.

The global urbanisation and industrialisation that began in the 1980s will be basically complete by the 2050s to 2060s. From East Asia to Southeast Asia, South Asia, North Africa, East Africa, West Africa — country after country will complete urbanisation and industrialisation in succession. In this world each wave pushes the next; do not imagine China can weld shut any door of industrialisation. To be clear, not only will it not be welded shut — Chinese capital is actively pulling the peoples of Asia, Africa, and Latin America across the threshold of industrialisation. That is dictated by the basic logic of capitalism.

The first wave behind China is Southeast Asia, South Asia, and North Africa and the Middle East, which already possess a certain industrial strength and are now rapidly industrialising. The second wave will most likely be East Africa. The common language of business and education in these places is basically English; those that are not English-speaking, like Algeria, are also shifting toward English.

The new industrialised countries, having attracted a flood of foreign capital and being dependent on foreign trade, have begun to attach growing importance to English throughout society. The Gulf states, short of population, bring in large numbers of foreign workers. Nepalis, Indians, and Pakistanis going to work in the Gulf resemble Sichuanese going to work in Shenzhen: while young, you are used; when older, you return home to farm and retire. Likewise, a Sichuanese going to Shenzhen must learn Mandarin, and a Nepali going to work in the Gulf must learn English. The vast flows of labour, capital, and other factors of production will not stop for a single day; English, as the medium, is used at every moment in this globalised world. Whether or not the Chinese have the ability to make people switch languages, even if they had the will, there is no way to stop the world for twenty years or more to switch languages.

As for the lingua franca of science and technology, among the powers with real strength — Europe, America, Japan, South Korea, and India — except for a slight chance that Japan and South Korea might turn toward Chinese, the rest can be considered impossible. Europe and America will relatively decline; the Southern countries led by India and Vietnam will rise rapidly. On the whole, China's scientific peak, at most, is 50% of the world's, and even this peak cannot be maintained long. Everyone else knows English, and you know English too — how can you force others to switch to

Chinese? China's vigorous development of domestic English-language journals shows that its rulers have a clear-headed understanding of this point.

In sum, Vietnam's move reflects the basic judgement of the non-Chinese world about globalisation, and deserves attention. I look forward to subsequent historical developments putting my analysis and speculation to the test.

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